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Feeling The Burn

When we arrived at her place, Danni and I separated to shower and change. Then I went down to the kitchen to start dinner.

My first time here, I quickly realized Danni wasn't the greatest shopper in the world. Bare cupboards. A nearly empty fridge. A drawer full of well-worn take-out menus. The clues were everywhere.

Apparently, the woman who put so much effort into caring for her teammates didn't apply that same zeal to caring for herself.

Go ahead and take a minute to get over the shock.

The situation was unacceptable to me, so I took action. The freezer, fridge and cabinets are now stocked, the spice rack is loaded and I maintain a steady flow of fresh ingredients each week.

Perhaps that *personal chef* remark was a little too flippant. Without invitation, I had basically laid siege to Danni's kitchen and made it my own. So maybe I deserve what I get.

Whatever the case, the good news was that I almost always had supplies on hand to pull a meal together. Tonight was no exception, and I quickly gathered what I needed.

Chicken, tomatoes and onion on the fresh side, along with olive oil and some seasonings.

The tomatoes and onion were diced a few minutes later. I rubbed the chicken with a blend of salt, pepper and garlic powder and put it in a frying pan with the onion and a little oil to brown.

Behind me, the dogs were in their requisite positions, patrolling the floor. Not one morsel was getting past those two.

In a medium bowl, I made a sauce of the tomatoes, olive oil, basil, rosemary and more garlic. I was just stirring the mixture into the pan when Danni appeared.

"Jesus!" she said. "Everything you make smells delicious! I should have hired you to cook for me years ago."

I stopped stirring and raised an eyebrow at her.

"I look like hired help to you?" I bristled.

She looked at me for a second, then down at my hand and back to me. Without thinking about it, I had pointed the wooden spoon I was using directly at her, and her expression said, *You might want to put that down before I decide to stick it somewhere.*

We had another little stare down - cause, you know... *fighters* - then I started to brandish the spoon like a sword.

She laughed, loudly and openly, and I was reminded of another 'discovery' I'd made recently: I love the sound of her laugh. Not exactly a *eureka*-type revelation because it had always been true, but I'd never thought much about it before.

So why was I thinking about it now?

I've been asking myself questions like that a lot, lately. More and more each day.

Little did I know something was about to happen that would blow all that away.

With the standoff brought to a peaceful end, I went back to stirring. Danni stepped up behind me to look over my shoulder at what I had cooking. As she did so, she laid one hand on my shoulder and the other on my hip. A simple, common-sense maneuver to steady both of us and make certain she didn't accidentally knock me into the stove.

She looked and she sniffed and she seemed genuinely pleased with the feedback she got from her senses.

Meanwhile, my senses had suddenly set my mind and body on fire, and I was acutely aware of every little detail.

Touch: With no effort at all, I could provide a precise list of every point of contact between us. Her hand on my hip. The other on my shoulder. Her arm brushing against me. My other hip nestled against her waist. The swell of her breast pressed firmly against my back. The combined heat of our bodies threatened to burn me.

Scent: Though she did not often wear perfume, there is a distinctive scent to her shampoo. She's used it for as long as I can remember, and I've always liked it. But lately, I can't get it out of my head. And with her standing so close... it was intoxicating.

Sight: I turned to look at her with a blank look on my face. I saw the joy in her smile and the carefree way she was willing to show me her teeth - which I've noticed is not something she often does. Trying to hide some self-perceived flaw I couldn't spot, maybe. Her hair was loose and soft and eminently touchable. I followed a tendril as it cascaded down and spiraled along the front of her shirt. I noticed how the angle of her head exposed the chords of her neck. The sight drew me in like a magnet.

I will never know what it was about that moment. Part of me knew what was happening, while most of me was confused. But the sudden, mad rush of it was unexplainable, and it made all of me a little afraid.

"You okay?" she asked.

I quickly boxed my emotions back up and shoved them in the corner.

"Sure," I said.

Nope, I thought.

She watched for a few seconds. Unconvinced.

I went back to stirring the chicken.

"Can you grab the pasta?" I asked.

The box of macaroni was right there on the counter. I could have gotten it with ease. But I needed to put some space between us. Even a foot or two seemed important.

She opened the box and handed it to me, and I felt the heat again when our fingers touched. I quickly turned to dump it in the pot.

"You're acting funny," she said.

There was no questioning tone to her words. No room left for doubt. Something was up, and she knew it.

"I'm fine," I said. "You wanna get the plates out? This'll be ready as soon as the pasta's done."

I could feel her eyes on my back, but I dared not turn around. Eventually, she decided to let it go.

The atmosphere as we ate was cool, but not uncomfortable. We talked a little about the tournament. We worried a bit about Emma, with both of us wishing that she and Tiffany perform well without running into each other along the way. We knew it wasn't possible to have both, but, if we could delude ourselves for a few more days, why not?

Mostly, we were quiet. No doubt, she was thinking about slapping me and demanding to know what my problem was. I spent the time trying to figure out what the hell had just happened.

I told myself this was what I'd been waiting for. The moment I had been so eager to force that night on the boardwalk had finally come of its own accord. It had been creeping up for months. Inching along with little touches and quiet reflections. But I couldn't explain the sudden leap from *maybe* to *right this damn second!* It felt like something inside me had snapped. Like I was losing my mind.

But then, maybe I wasn't.

Maybe this was love, finally taking root the way it was supposed to. The way Danni wanted it to.

The way I wanted it to?

Yes.

After months and months of not being sure - and not knowing how or if I ever would be - suddenly I was. There was no denying it. The pull was incredible. I wanted to kiss her. To feel her body against mine. To hold her, and to be held.

But, boy... did my timing ever suck.

After all this time, thirty-six hours before we took off for one of the biggest events of Danni's career didn't seem like the right time to get tangled up in this.

I became determined. I would bottle it up. I had waited this long, and I could damn-well wait a little longer. I would not let this become a distraction.

This was no problem as we finished and cleaned up, but then came the time when we kick back and catch up on some of our favorite shows together in *Danni's room*.

Despite the fact that it's her own private space, it turns out I factor into it. My face peeks out here and there in the photos she's selected, so I guess I've been part of it since before I even knew it existed. But I have since now here many times. So many that I have my own spot.

On the couch.

Right next to Danni.

Not just next to her, but curled up into her. Our legs would touch. Our elbows would rub. When we turned to face each other, our heads would only be a few inches apart.

Never before has this been an issue. I have shared a cage with this woman. We have grappled and wrestled and struggled against each other. Body-to-body contact is not a new experience for us.

But tonight, it did not seem like a safe place to be.

Reason and common-sense dictated that there was only one way to solve this problem. I would have to just suck it up and deal. But I still didn't understand what happened earlier, and I didn't trust myself at all.

So, I chose a different way, and it didn't work.

Moving to the other end of the couch would be too conspicuous. Instead, I tried to stay close, but not too close. Leaving just a small gap between us. But that left me squarely in the no-man's-land of the center cushion, with nothing and no one to lean on.

I ended up sitting straight up like I was tied to a pole. Afraid to get closer but not wanting to run away. My hands folded awkwardly in my lap. Like a teen on a first date, wanting to seem cool while not giving off the wrong impression.

And I could not have been more obvious if I tried.

"Alright, enough," Danni said. "What the hell is going on?"

"I..."

I paused. What should I do?

Option one: Tell her.

It was the honest choice, but it would undoubtedly lead to action. She had made no secret of the fact that she'd been waiting... her emotions and desires quelled by love and patience. But that would all end here. If I told her what was happening, the cork was coming out of the bottle and this night was headed for the bedroom.

Result? Distraction. A good distraction no doubt, but a distraction nonetheless.

Verdict? Unacceptable. Not now. Not with so much on the line for her. I would not let this happen again.

Option two: Lie.

Tell her nothing was wrong, and stick to my story. This option came with the understanding that she wasn't going to buy it. Not for an instant. But she would have to accept that she couldn't force the truth out of me. Which, in turn, would make her angry. It would also cause her to worry.

Result? Distraction. Far worse than option one.

Verdict? Unacceptable.

That left option three: The middle ground.

"You're right," I admitted. "Something's going on. Something we need to talk about. Just not now."

"Why not?"

"Because we're getting on a plane in..."

"Oh, no, no no!" she snapped. "You promised not to do that. That we wouldn't put things on hold."

"I know what I said, but this tournament is right on top of us. You don't need a distraction, now."

"And you don't think this is a distraction?"

"Well, how about you let me finish and then make that determination?"

"How about you just tell me what the hell is happening? Something is obviously bothering you, and you know I hate playing these games."

Another thing I love about her is her tenacity, but, strangely enough, I didn't love it so much right this very second.

"Alright, look... this is getting blown out of proportion. So, let's clear something up: there is no problem, OK? You and me? We're good. Better now than ever. There is nothing to worry about."

"So, what the hell is wrong with you then?"

I let out a frustrated sigh.

"Why do you have to aggravate me like this?"

"Me? You're the one keeping secrets!"

"I'm not... it's not..."

I ran my hand through my hair so hard I almost tore some of it out.

"There is no secret. I just feel like you and I need to talk."

"Ah... here we go!"

I put my hands out in front of me in a *just stop* gesture.

"Shut up!" I snapped. "Just shut up, and let me finish."

We glared at each other for a long time until she finally relented and gestured for me to continue.

"This *talk* isn't going to be some earth-shattering thing. I think it's time to discuss about what's next for us, that's all."

"And why can't we just do that now?"

"Because..."

Because what, genius? Where are you going with this?

"Because I don't know exactly what I'm trying to say, or where I'm going with this or anything," I admitted. "I only know that I'm happy, and I think you're happy and so we need to talk. Make sure we're in the same place so we don't screw things up again. And I'm genuinely sorry this came up now. I didn't mean to upset you. Trust me. There's nothing to worry about."

She sat back. Somewhat pacified, but still suspicious.

"There's no problem?"

"None."

"And you were acting like a whack job because...?"

"Because I am a whack job," I said. "I think that's established, at this point."

She took a second, then nodded thoughtfully. As if to say, *That's a fair point*. Which I found a little insulting, but I chose to stay on task.

"All I'm saying is, let's just let it go, for now. It's not anything crucial. It can wait until we get back."

"But we will talk about it," she said sternly.

"Yes, Ms. Danni," I dutifully responded.

"Don't be a smart-ass."

"Yes, Ms. Danni," I said again.

We had another long stare-down and I thought for sure we were about to renew the verbal fisticuffs. Instead, she signaled that the argument was over by turning on the TV.

Which brought us back to the seating issue.

After a moment's hesitation, I did what I should have done in the first place. I took my usual spot, curled my feet up and snuggled into her.

If she could wait all these months for me to get my act together, then I could hold myself together for a night.

But damn... it was hot in here.